Personality

By Gina Wendkos and Ellen Ratner

ELLEN: In America, you look around and you see all these images of people who you should be. People with long hair down to their waist, people with eyes that sparkle, people with clever accents, people who tell witty stories, people who have courage, people who make shyness an art form. There are so many images of people to choose from . . . everywhere.

INTRODUCTION

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(Lights up on woman sitting in chair, downstage, lighting cigarette. Her posture and accent is that of "Lorette," her mother, a Jewish cartoon figure of 54 years old. Lorette speaks to imaginary husband "Sol." He is stage left and never seen. Lorette speaks very stylized New York Jewishese.)

LORETTE: In America if you are not famous you are nothing more than a slimy cockroach, and you are quickly forgotten. When you are famous life is easy. Everyone wants to be your friend. They invite you to the right parties, they ask your opinion. Basically it is all of you that is enviable -- your hair, your smile, your figure, your face, your personality, everything. With her personality she should be listening. Ellen, are you listening to me? Ellen! *(With a slight change in posture woman becomes Ellen, Lorette's daughter. She is 30 years old, no strong accent.)*

ELLEN: Confidence? Please, that's easy. . . let's face it. We're living in New York City. Right? City of heroes. Isn't everyone here exactly the kind of person you want to be? Who should I be? I mean, I get along. I don't have all that much of a problem making friends. No, really I don't. They say, "Hi Ellen, how's life'!", and I say "Hi gang, life is swell." You see that's an attitude you have to have in N.Y.C, that things are swell. Just say it with me, things are swell. See! If you say it enough, it starts to have a nice ring to it. Things are swell. And when things aren't, if you want my opinion, say they are anyway. Because that's exactly what gets you over. There isn't a single person in this city that wants to hear, things suck.

(phone rings, Ellen picks up) Hello, hi Ma. Yes, I got the invitation. They're real nice. . .is Eileen happy with them? Well, I'm not sure yet. . . can't I come alone? No one right now. . . there is

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this one guy, but. . .well, I don't think it's really right, cause we just met. . . yeah, He's real nice. I'm sure he works. .. I don't know. . . I didn't ask him. . . if we see each other one more time I'll ask him ... about 5'11" maybe 6'. Yeah, he's handsome... like a Robert Deniro type. Ma, what is wrong with Italian? Why would that embarrass you? Tell me. Why?

LORETTE: I remember a few years ago, there was this bar mitzvah. Ellen was a little heavy then. So I said to her whatever you do, do not wear white. What color do you think she wore? White. She looked like a blimp. To this day people from that bar mitzvah still ask me, how is Ellen? Is she still a little chunky'!

ELLEN: I always wanted to wake up one morning with some guy and hear him on the phone. I wanted to lie in bed pretending to be asleep. I'll move my hair so that it covers the pillow but still shows my face and I'd lift up my hips so my waist looks smaller just like in the photos and I'll listen to this Jake or Rick or Tony guy on the phone, talking to one of his friends.

ELLEN AS JAKE OR RICK OR TONY: "Hey, buddy, how ya doin'? Listen I've got this girl here. Huh? Her name is Ellen. One of those round, hot Italians. Nah, met her on the street. I went up to her and said I've never wanted anyone like you, and she just looked at me and smiled. I knew once I touched her I'd never leave. Yeah, she's really something else. I could get lost in her hair alone, it's so long and gets everywhere but I want it."

ELLEN: That's the kind of conversation I imagine. Then this Jake or Rick or Tony guy would come in and see me posed like that. Even if he knows it's arranged he'll like it. He'll just look at me. Forget the personality for a minute. Sometimes I want to be wanted just for the way I walk.

LORETTE: There are a lot of pretty girls in this world, a lot of competition. So, it would seem to me that, it would be very difficult, if you're not so good looking, to get a man to take care of you. I told Ellen she should get a skill.

ELLEN: Money. Sure, got lots of it. Can't you tell? I never understood how to have money. . . the idea of becoming a career girl always seemed so stupid to me . . . of all the stupid advances of women, that has got to be the worst. What the hell is so liberating about leaving the home and kids for some stupid desk job. . .? *(Phone rings and Ellen picks up)*

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Hello, Hi Mom. Yeah, we had a great time.. Y'know one of those really fun nights, where everything went well. Mom, why do you ask me stuff like that? Cause I think it's sort of personal. No, I am not ashamed. . . it's just really personal. So what if he did? What difference does it make? What if he did sleep over, what does that mean?

LORETTE: Four men is the limit for a woman to sleep with before she gets a bad reputation. Number one is the one you lost your virginity to; it was summer, he had a nice car. Number two, that one's because you kind of forgot what it was like the first time. You were a little nervous. The third one is like practice - makes perfect. You're preparing yourself for number four, the one you're gonna marry. I tell Ellen the number is four. After that they call you a used car.

ELLEN: Pretty strict rules in this woman biz. As a kid it never mattered, you could climb trees and giggle. But now only one of those attitudes is allowed or you don't get over. It's OK. If you want to act tough, then people know who you are . . . on, she's a tough broad, watch out. And it's cool if you have pert breasts and giggle, then people know the score. But make a sexy girl tough and no one knows the right response. So you see, some days I'm a giggly type. I laugh at everything. I'm coy. I'm sweet. I'm available. And other days I'm a tough broad. That's where things get pretty confusing for the world at large.

LORETTE: Ellen. Ellen, Ellen, Ellen. She's thirty years old. She doesn't know what she wants to do with her life. When I was her age, I had two children, a home I could basically call my own and I was president of the P.T.A. Ellen never has any money. I told her a good job for her is word processing. You work in an office, you meet nice people. She won't investigate it. She's lazy and she's sloppy. She is not pretty per se. What man is gonna want her? You know what her problem is? She is not aware. Ellen would never have had such a lousy personality if she listened to me.

ELLEN: And the tension, the tension. It winds me up so bad. I'm pissed off. Real pissed off. So pissed off that I want to start a fight. I'm so finished with being that ugly, skinny little thing. All the Frenchmen in the cafes, all the Italians in the gondolas, all the Indians on the reservations, all the children hiding under the swings, all the old people hiding under wrinkles. It's them, all

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of them. . . whispering things to me . . . *(phone rings)* they make me who I am. *(Ellen picks up)* Hello. No, Ma, he didn't call. . . how do I know? Huh, are you satisfied. . . you said he wouldn't and he didn't. So do you have the balloons out?? Are you throwing a party? Huh? Did you make a cake while you're at it? No, no! I'll say whatever I want at this point. I am sick and tired of hearing how I should do it, how I should say it, how I should act it . . . My personality, Ma. WHAT IS WRONG WITH MY PERSONALITY? WHO DO YOU WANT ME TO BE? HUH? WHO?

(Ellen flashes through a number of "PERSONALITIES")

GAME SHOW LADY: *(Midwest accent)* I'm going to be on the 10,000 Dollar Pyramid. I'm so excited. You see I read everything. Books, magazines, backs of cereal boxes. Just ask me anything. "What is the capital of Burma?" "Rangoon." "How does the whojoo bird protect itself?" "Its fur inflates into a protective covering." I know it all. Animal, vegetable, and mineral. They also like me on TV because I have a bubbly personality…

SPANISH CHA-CHA GIRL: *(Low-class Spanish accent)* Maria, conyo, Julio, si. I love this place. Mongo Santa Maria *(dances and sings)* Julio get me a gin and tonic. Julio, he's my boyfriend. He and I are going to be in a contest and we're going to win. Julio thinks the prize is fifty dollars but I'm going to surprise him. The prize is going to be me. And I'm not going to use birth control. So that way I get the ring, the car, and Julio.

VIDEO GIRL: *(Brooklynese accent)* Hey, hi guys, hi Rusty. How ya doin'? Slap me five. Hi Pee Wee. How ya doin'? *(Pantomimes playing PacMan)* Oh boy, 500 points, I don't believe it. Better watch out you're gonna be eaten. Better watch out. Told you. *(Makes the sound of Pac Man)* See I do this game better than I know anything else. See. People say I could go pro at this game. Then I could quit school.

MISS AMERICA: *(Southern drawl; sings "Here She Comes Miss America")* Thank you all, thank you so much. It's been a wonderful year being Miss America. I traveled around the world and saw so many underprivileged people. You should see how these poor darlin's live. They have animals right in the house, So I turned and said *(sings)* "We are the world. We are the children." That's just one of the many things I've done as Miss America.

HOUSEWIFE: *(Nancy Reagan accent)* I take pride in the things I do. Every single one of them. Some

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women keep their homes in horrible condition. They serve jelly from the jar and it develops and unsightly crust around the rim. Oh yes, and they use paper napkins. REALLY! Paper napkins. *(screams at kids)* TOMMY, JIMMY, GET AWAY FROM THAT REFRIGERATOR BEFORE I CUT YOUR HANDS OFF. *(resumes Nancy Reagan personality)* I use cloth napkins only. I have several patterns. Checkers, stripes, floral prints, even polka dots.. *(screams at kids)* DID YOU HEAR WHAT I SAID? GET UPSTAIRS WITH YOUR BROTHER.

WAITRESS: *(low-class urban accent)* Hi, hon, coffee? How ya doin' today? What's it gonna be? Whole wheat, white or rye? Cole slaw or French-fries? Anything to drink? Coke. Here you go.. I run this counter like clockwork. By the time they have their cigarettes out of their pocket I get a cup of java in front of their face. *(ding)* When I hear that bell I run. I don't care what anyone says anything made with cheese gets soggy under these lights. I have a lot of miles on these feet. But when my customers come in they know they're gonna get quick courteous service. Not many people give you that at all.

(Medley and frenzy of characters blends into a cacophony of all characters until final frenzy-woman switches accents and characters.)

GAME SHOW LADY: uh. *(buzz)* Kentucky. Tennessee I always get that one right.

SPANISH CHA-CHA GIRL: What do you mean you're dancing with someone else Julio?

VIDEO GIRL: Hey, what's the matter with this machine? I never lose my quarter.

MISS AMERICA: Let me keep the crown just one more year. I promise I'll give it back. Just one more year.

HOUSEWIFE: I only have paper napkins. I only have paper napkins.

WAITRESS: What do you mean my coffee is bitter? This is a fresh pot. Why don't you go somewhere else buddy?

(Frenzy flip out-shaking-etc. Pause, breathe. Switch to ELLEN)

ELLEN: What is a personality? Huh Ma? What is a personality? So, I said to the Frenchmen in the cafes, the Italians in the gondolas, to the Indians on the reservations, so I said to her, I'm lazy, I'm sloppy, and I have flat feet. Take me or leave me. Hopefully she'll take me.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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